Prominent among the postulates that have shaped our thinking is the centrality of the US to the current international system. It is evident, however, that the two ‘forever wars’ in Afghanistan and Iraq have greatly affected that polity. That one was marked by conceptual confusion and the other was altogether avoidable is beside the point. The rationale of both conflicts may continue to be debated by those still interested. But what is done is done, and the US has come out much worse.

There was also a parallel economic pressure growing in this very period, one paradoxically created by the US on itself. The globalization model that many Americans advocated for so fervently has had a corrosive impact on its own strengths and capabilities. The last and obviously weakest justification for its continuation is that of the importance of the dependencies that it has already created. But the implications for American manufacturing prowess and technology leads were visible enough to be expressed, first as a political backlash and, thereafter, as a national security challenge. The Trump presidency certainly marked a turning point, but many of the debates matured further during the Biden Administration to emerge as a systemic posture. The net outcome of these developments is a strategic evolution of the US that is reflected in a changing stance abroad and different terms of engagement that it now offers to the world.

This is not a situation that has emerged overnight. On the contrary, rhetoric notwithstanding, we have seen a growing caution in US power projection since 2008. In tandem, there have been persistent efforts to address its overextension. In fact, there is a consistency in this regard over three Administrations that it may not readily admit to. Whether it is footprint, extent of involvement or the nature of activities, we are witnessing a very different America. And this America is moving towards greater realism, both about itself and the world, as it seeks to achieve global objectives in a more cost-effective manner. It could assume a broader posture as an off-shore balancer in more regions in a way that protects its influence without expanding its risks. This has different aspects, key among them a striving for a better balance between its domestic revival and its external obligations.

There is a sharper recognition, too, of an emerging multipolarity and growing strategic autonomy that characterizes the current era. This impels a quest for new options, even while consolidating old relationships. There is also not only an acute consciousness of the challenges to its position but a